to see how it affects him." Unlikely, quips Sharma. The cynical word in his early days was: "*Kursi sab sikha deti hai* (power teaches you everything)." He's yet to put on arrant displays of political shrewdness, but indications are that he's catching on fast.

In the Rajasthan BJP, that may be more necessity than luxury. Jully likes to talk about it—all the better to sow confusion behind enemy lines. As early as January, he amped up talk that BJP worthies were out to sabotage the party's Lok Sabha chances in order to unsettle the new CM. During this budget session, he again put out word that some leaders are out to finish Sharma, that half a dozen ministers could be dropped, and that the public has been talking about his differences with deputy CM Diya Kumari, originally a strong contender for chief ministership herself. When asked by INDIA TODAY, she categorically denied any problem.

But the chance for insubordination lurks elsewhere: ministers and senior bureaucrats occasionally ignored the Chief Minister's Office (CMO) in key transfers. Sharma struck back; he changed transfer orders in the irrigation department and shifted the PWD head. Yet, he's avoiding outright confrontation—a far cry from the way Gehlot and Raje used to crush rivals or troublemakers. The circumspection could be personal, or an outcome of the high command's word. The bosses in Delhi are keeping a vigilant oversight for sure. That's what enabled Sharma to court ministerial annoyance by not letting them pick secretaries of their choice—a leeway that mostly ends up favouring caste fellows. The CM himself has yet to develop favourites among ministers or officers, though at times he does rely on old acquaintances.

A reasoned calibration also marks his approach on another tricky subject. He hasn't gone after Raje or Gehlot. Instead, he has twice visited their residences, a departure from the duo's own churlish tradition: they didn't speak with each other for well over a decade.

CAMP FIRE

- **Kirodi Lal Meena quit as agriculture minister on June 4, claiming it was penitence for LS losses in the seven seats the PM assigned him**
- **He was denied a deputy CM's post, a significant ministry, a say in postings**
- **Resignation not accepted, but Meena is not attending office or assembly**
- **The CM forced to firefight for controversial education minister Madan Dilawar**
- **Dilawar created a row by standing against English medium and for taunting a tribal leader with a DNA test**

SHARMA HASN'T GONE AFTER EITHER RAJE OR GEHLOT. BARRING A NEW CHIEF SECRETARY, SOME TOP OFFICIALS OF THE GEHLOT ERA TOO HAVE SURVIVED

Indeed, Raje may not have been spared had any of her arch-rivals been sworn in in place of Sharma. As for the alleged scams of the Gehlot era, he says he won't "spare anyone, whosoever he is". But he's not inclined towards witch-hunting. Says an officer, "Occasionally, on getting a complaint, he tells us to fix the errant individual, but when we present the case file, he often lets it go if there is no strong evidence."

That moderation is visible also in his handling of officialdom. A section is upset that he did not sideline those who got plum postings under the Congress: additional chief secretary, finance, Akhil Arora, Jaipur police commissioner Biju Joseph et al. Evidently, he has taken to heart Modi's public counsel against mass transfers; officials, he was told, belong to no party and it was up to the political masters to bend them to their will. That led to the judgement in some quarters that the old Congress regime continues, but this overlooks some key changes.

NEW DELHI'S HAND

The most noticeable: chief secretary Sudhansh Pant, said to be handpicked by the Prime Minister's Office to galvanise an administration infamous for its lethargy, so endemic that it keeps Rajasthan slow-moving even among backward states. Pant is making surprise visits, and has a say in postings, restoring stature to an office invariably overshadowed by the CMO in past decades. Gehlot allowed himself a dig at Sharma on this, saying it's actually Pant who runs the government. Some within the BJP even blame Pant for the party's Lok Sabha showing. That spurred Sharma to fortify the CMO. This week, he divided work between two of his lieutenants: additional chief secretary Shikhar Aggarwal and principal secretary Alok Gupta, who also handles recommendations from the RSS.

Sharma did start on the front foot. His first policy act was to set up two special investigation teams: one on the state's endemic exam leaks, one on the December killing of Karni Sena leader Sukhdev Gogamedi. A flurry of mafiosi arrests followed, of both the paper leak sort and the regular variety. He claims over half of the BJP's poll promises have been met. But the other 'half' could fell a pro. Among his legacies is a Rs 70,947 crore fiscal deficit—if he has any formula to hack that down, it's still secret. An even taller peak lurks in the Rs 91,000 crore owed to power companies, a grim thought after a summer blackened by power cuts. Devotion perchance offers solace. His habits there are vintage Bharatpur: go-to Krishna bhajans and Goverdhan dham yatras, now down to once a month. But the Brahmin farmer's son will need some miracles on the temporal front too. ■